

Interviewer: Okay, recording is on. As we mentioned before, we are curious about your views on romantic relationships and we think your experiences will contribute to our project. Before we start, would you mind if I record this interview?

Participant (speaker): Yes, yes.

Interviewer: Okay. How old are you?

Participant [16-20].

Interviewer: How long have you been together with your partner?

Participant: It's almost [6-10] months.

Interviewer: [6-10] months?

Participant: Exactly. [6-10] months.

Interviewer: Do you have children?

Participant No.

Interviewer: Who do you live with at home?

Participant My family. I mean my nuclear family. Should I count them one by one?

Interviewer: Well, no, no need. What is your main source of income?

Participant: I mean, where does the [occupation] have a source of income, normally from the family.

Interviewer: And how would you like us to address your partner? Girlfriend, wife, lover...

Participant Lover or girlfriend.

Interviewer: Okay. So can you tell me the story of how you met and how your relationship started?

Participant: Let me tell you, it was on [Social Media]. She texted, but I wasn't thinking about anything in detail at first. Later, when we met, we met immediately after [1-5] days or so, we met face to face. After that, for about [1-5] month and a half, there were dates like this, at least [1-5] days a week, [1-5] days a week. It was obvious that it was going to happen later. It happened in [1-5] month and a half. We became lovers.

Interviewer: And how would you rate the quality of your own relationship compared to your friends' relationships?

Participant: I see it as high, I mean naturally.

Interviewer: Uh-huh. So can you explain this a little bit?

Participant: I mean, the current relationships are a bit different. You know, they are fragile. But I don't think mine is like that because at least I and my partner are conscious at some points. Anyway, she also studies [field]. She knows more or less how to approach. We don't have many problems. Of course, there are some special days. For example: when she has some pressure on herself or something. She may reflect that to me, but I think he is fine now.

Interviewer: So how many romantic relationships have you had in the past?

Participant: So it is [1-5] or [1-5].

Interviewer: How would you rate the quality of your current relationship compared to your previous relationships?

Participant: Way above them. I mean, it's a bit more like the teenage years. It was something like that, but a bit more logic involved in this relationship. Emotions are already there. But I think it's mostly better quality than previous ones.

Interviewer: So what makes a relationship high quality for you?

Participant Respect.

Interviewer: Mm-hmm. Is there anything else you would like to add?

Participant: I mean, respect and a certain level of mutual understanding, I think. The ability for both of you to sit down and talk about similar things, to have conversations, makes the relationship last longer. Because in some way, something within you grabs your interest. Something different grabs your interest. Since you talk about that, I think the relationship can last longer.

Interviewer: So what makes it low quality?

Participant: It's toxicity. I mean, it could be jealousy. It could be conflict. Conflict is very common in current relationships. Other than that, there isn't much else. But it's toxicity.

Interviewer: Then you think that what makes a close relationship strong is respect and understanding.

Participant: Uh-huh, yes.

Interviewer: So how do you know that you are in a relationship where there is respect and understanding?

Participant: Respect starts with how you address each other. Nowadays, supposedly there are couples who insult each other... using things at the level of insults. Or when they get to the point of breaking up, both sides badmouth each other, for example. I know that this doesn't happen. Knowing that it doesn't happen makes me more comfortable talking about it. As for mutual understanding, nowadays we comment on common things. We pick up something from the agenda and so on. When you mostly find something in common, you can build mutual understanding. You say, 'We are okay with this, fine.'

Interviewer: So, what are the most important things in a relationship for you?

Participant: The most important things... Well, first, there needs to be sevgi, of course. Sevgi is a must in a relationship. But as I said, it's respect again; respect is the most important thing in a relationship. Even if you break up, you still have respect for the other person, and you tolerate some things and let it go. Because if there isn't respect... the first rule is like having respect, but that's how it is

Interviewer: So, what is aşk (love) to you?

Participant: It's like making something out of nothing, let's say.

Interviewer: How important is aşk (love) in a relationship?

Participant: It's important in the initial phase. You want to talk to the person you're in aşk (love) with. But aşk (love) can also lower expectations. I mean, you might have fallen deeply in aşk (love), but as you get to know that person, you might think, 'Is this the person we were in aşk (love) with? This person is normal, we were in aşk (love) for nothing then.' So, aşk (love) is important at first. After that, logic comes into play. Aşk (love) takes a back seat a bit.

Interviewer: So, how do you know if your partner loves you?

Participant: Hmm... How do I know... It's generally understood. From their behavior and actions, how they act when they're with you. Also, if you see how they behave when you're talking to other people, you know. Then you think, 'Okay, this person loves me, this woman loves me, or this man

loves me.' Especially if they like a nice emotion or expression of yours, you can tell from their face.

Interviewer: What challenges do you face in your relationship?

Participant: In my current relationship, it's [Team]. She's a [Team] fan. I'm a [Team] fan, so when we lose... actually, it's not because of that, it's because of me. I say things like, 'Why are these people so against [Team]?' And she says, 'No, you're the one starting it, these people aren't like that. When you do something, they show you that they beat you with this fan spirit,' and so on. But other than that, there hasn't been a major issue. It's something we do knowingly between us.

Interviewer: Do you and your girlfriend fight?

Participant: We haven't done it for a very long time. But when we do, you know, in a day or two we're figuring it out. I don't remember us fighting very detailed, maybe [6-10] in total. maybe once or twice a month, if something important happens.

Interviewer: So how do you resolve these disputes?

Participant: I mean usually...It usually happens at night. In the morning, everyone just calms down. Maybe not until the evening of that day, with a proper conversation, with both sides explaining their problems, that's how things are solved. We're trying to get through the problem. But for the most part, you always come, if you love, you have to come.

Interviewer: So what are these fights about?

Participant: Generally, this discussion happened because of the most recent one, this one about [Team] or something like that. Other than that, maybe [1-5] months ago, maybe [1-5] months ago. But I don't know what it was about, but it was a trivial thing, and then we started laughing. and I was already starting to make fun of the discussion we had. So it's not a big, big deal.

Interviewer: Well, you mentioned before that you resolved the argument by talking. What are the other ways of maintaining a relationship?

Participant: I think different experiences for excitement, for example, different places you haven't visited. There might be a place you've never been. I give possible examples since we are students. For example, when you enter a nicer different environment you can do that. When you went and did different activities together, you liked each other. You know, it extends the time that already exist. And there's that bonding with each other. It increases the bond too. Because the

more memories you make, the more memories you experience with that person. you're already saying that: I mean, we did this, we did that, we did this, it was good. It's like this. It's even more beautiful when you think about it.

Interviewer: So would you say that this relationship is good for you?

Participant: Sure, I will. I can't do that if I don't say it anyway.

Interviewer: And why?

Participant: Because a relationship needs to motivate me. So motivating me is like this: In life there are already a lot of problems like economic issues, country affairs and so on. You know, love is actually an escape from there. And when you get there, it relaxes you. It motivates you. It makes you feel you're thinking. You start to think more logically. So you say, for example. I'm doing this wrong in real life. I need to do this better. You know, a little bit more like this. It's a cozy place, actually. It calms you down. You're already calm around someone you love. You need to be calm. You can think better. That kind of thing.

Interviewer: Well, can you give a concrete example of what you said?

Participant: I think studying together with your girlfriend or something like that is a concrete example of this, for example, from exam stress or studying for an exam. Or for example, you will make a decision that will be a turning point. It would be at least a little better if you make that decision with your girlfriend or with your boyfriend for the girl. You can think of more logical things. Especially if the person on the other side understands you, if they know this side of you, you can say more logical things.

Interviewer: So did this relationship change you?

Participant: I mean, if you love someone, you already change. I mean you change, you increase the things that they like. After that, for example, the way you dress is like that. If the girl you love says "Wear this" or something like that, you have to wear it, sometimes you don't have to do much, of course it changes. It changes the way you talk. Maybe she can change her view of life, but it starts with love at first. Otherwise, if you do it just to stand next to you, you are wrong.

Interviewer: So how did it change you?

Participant: Because she is a calm person, she changed me to be a little calmer, to be a little calmer in these kinds of things, to not be impulsive when making decisions. She changed me in

this kind of thing, I can be a little more calm and think, and sometimes he changes me about his clothing style.

Interviewer: What about your partner, did he change during the relationship?

Participant She has changed. I mean, you can ask her, but she must have changed because the girl I first met is not the same as the girl I know now. She is becoming more and more the one I like better, the one I like more and more.

Interviewer: So how do these changes happen?

Participant: The changes are a bit more like this, how can I put it? Different from the girl you know, in terms of her life view, you know, when you look at it, it seems like she has no interest in that subject, but you look at it, she actually started researching with you, she started reading, and so on and so forth. So you see these things. And when you see that, of course you are happy.

Interviewer: So do you feel safe in your relationship?

Participant: Yes I do.

Interviewer: Could you elaborate on this a little bit more?

Participant: So what I mean by feeling safe is not that there will be danger from the outside, I mean, if something is already coming, what can the girl do, naturally, but you know, feeling safe is like this, when I go to nicer places with her, of course I feel safe because she knows, I know. When you know a little bit, you feel safe in common places and places you like, so you know what will happen and what will not happen there.

Interviewer: Now I will show you something from the scale, but if you can't read it, it's okay. I will read it again anyway.

My partner really listens to me. One is not true at all, nine is completely true. What would be your answer?

Participant Eight.

Interviewer: Now I will show one more scale.

How sensitive is my partner to my needs in general? One is not true at all, Nine is completely true.

Participant: So that's also eight.

Interviewer: Now you answered eight to my first question that my partner usually really listens to me. And why eight?

Participant: Because I know that she listens, you know, sometimes when I do a lot of things in areas she doesn't like, she says yes, but because I don't talk in areas she doesn't like very much. That's why I feel that she listens. When I ask questions, I get answers, etc. I gave her eight because of that.

Interviewer: You also gave an eight to my second question, "My partner is usually sensitive to my needs". Why eight?

Participant: Because when I need something, for example, I ask her if I should buy this, and she says that it is better for you to buy this than that. She knows me better than me at some points. I gave eight because of that, because of that style.

Interviewer: I hope you don't mind me asking and please feel free to tell me if it is sensitive for you to share. We would like to know more about your physical intimacy as a couple. How often do you have sexual intercourse these days?

Participant: No.

Interviewer: If you do not want to answer, then I will skip this part.

No, it's not that I don't want to answer, what kind of intimacy, physically?

Interviewee: Physical closeness, yes.

Participant: I mean, no, we didn't do much, that's why I said no.

Interviewer: OK.

Participant: It's a different thing, we actually know people's stuff and stuff. So it is difficult.

Interviewer: Okay, I will show you another scale now. How would you rate the satisfaction of your relationship? Minus ten is completely dissatisfied and ten is completely satisfied.

Participant: I think there are eight again. There are eight-nine.

Interviewer: Uh-huh... you answered eight. So why eight and not seven or nine?

Participant: Because at some points, I don't want to call it a deficiency, but it needs to be done that way. Now if I say nine or ten, I would be exaggerating myself. If I say seven or something, if

I say six or five, it would be like lying to yourself. I mean, really. Because I'm comfortable. It's eight, I said a number I liked, eight as a guarantee.

Interviewer: So did your relationship meet your expectations?

Participant: Yes. Because my initial expectation was not that much, just at first we kind of got to know each other, blah, blah, blah. But there's an eight-nine right now. I mean, she's meeting my expectations and everything very comfortably.

Interviewer: We are about to finish now. Let me summarize what we talked about. You have been together for [6-10] or [6-10] months. You met on social media and started a romantic relationship after [1-5] month and a half. Compared to your friends' relationships, you see your relationship as better quality. You think that other relationships are more fragile. You think that love is important at the dating stage, but at later stages you think that logic is more important. What is good for you in a relationship is that it motivates you.

Participant: Yes.

Interviewer: It gives you an escape from the environment.

Participant: Yes, that's right.

Interviewer: So in the relationship, you think your girlfriend changed you and you think she changed too. So is there anything else you would like to add?

Participant: No, I don't have anything special to say. I mean, I don't know if it's like an advice thing, like I'm a very old person right now, but

Interviewer: No, you can add it too.

Participant: No, not very much, but that's what I mean by respect. You know, after a certain point you think: I'll get married at worst. You know, what I mean by worst is something like [1-5] years later, [1-5] years later, after you get out of university, when you start earning money somehow, what I mean by respect is actually this: I show respect to this person, and this person shows respect to me in the same way, and the duration of the relationship is prolonged because of our respect for each other. When you make a mistake, of course you will have problems, but when you are respectful or when you listen to each other, you win in every way. That's why I already say respect.

Interviewer: So that's the end of the study, but before we finish I'd like to ask a few questions about how we will handle the data. Because this is a research project, we want to be as transparent as possible from an ethical point of view. And so we want to know which data sharing option is the most suitable for you. So the first option is to share parts of the transcript of our interview. None of these transcripts will contain any information that can identify you. So your de-identified interview transcript can be read by other researchers. The second option, if you don't mind and if you want to be a little more bold, is to share your entire interview transcript anonymized and stripped of sensitive and overly identifying details. With this option, there is a slim chance that someone who knows you will be able to piece together the details of the interview transcript and narrow down the choices of who they believe you are among their colleagues. Again, I want to emphasize that no sensitive information will be shared. Which one would you choose?

Participant: No, I will choose the second one, so it is not a problem for me. In fact, it would be better for you to use it because it has fewer subjects.

Interviewer: Yes, let me stop the recording. One minute.

Transcription Note: The interviewer is written as the interviewer and the speaker is written as the participant.